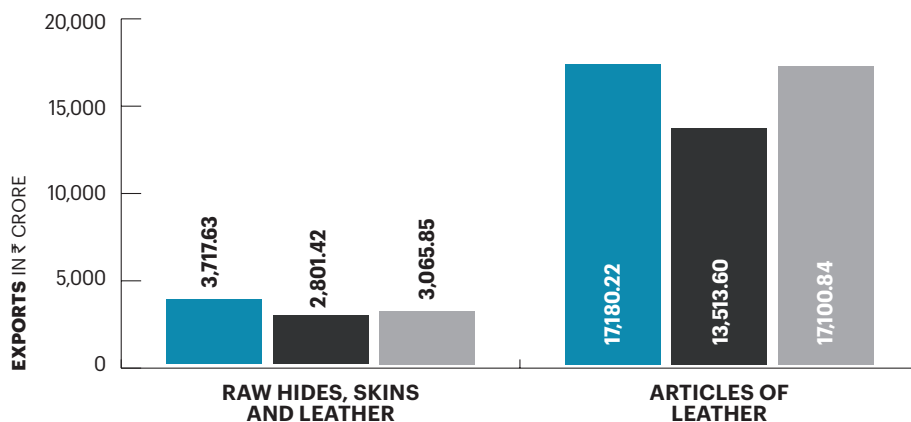


MOVING NORTH

WITH THE PANDEMIC ALMOST OVER, EXPORTS OF LEATHER AND LEATHER PRODUCTS ARE SLOWLY GAINING TRACTION

■ 2019-20 ■ 2020-21
■ 2021-22 (APR-FEB)

SOURCE DEPARTMENT OF COMMERCE, EXPORT-IMPORT DATA BANK

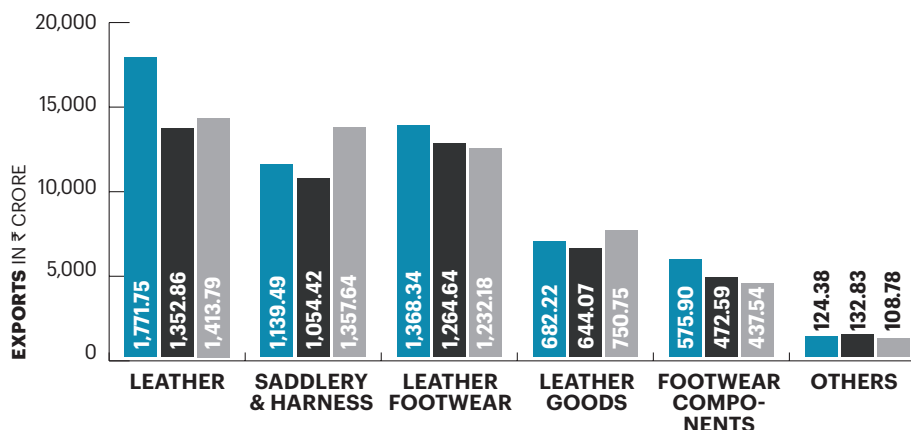


JAGGED RECOVERY

NOT ALL CATEGORIES OF PRODUCTS ARE RECOVERING FROM THE PANDEMIC'S BLOWS

■ 2018-19 ■ 2019-20
■ 2020-21

SOURCE COUNCIL FOR LEATHER EXPORTS



of leather exports from India to the UK, the US, China, and the Gulf countries, among others. The city's leather industry—including tanneries and leather goods manufacturers—provides direct and indirect employment to about a million people in Kanpur and Unnao districts.

For perspective, with annual production of 3 billion sq. ft of leather in 2021, which constitutes 13 per cent of the world's total leather production, the leather industry is among the top 10 foreign exchange earners for India.

With three tanneries and two manufacturing units, Homera exports safety and casual shoes to China, Italy, France, the US, and Germany. Ashraf Rizwan, another

founder of the company, says, "We clocked ₹100 crore revenue from exporting leather stuff abroad in FY22. It is a big rise from ₹65 crore exports in FY21, which was marred by the Covid-19 waves. But 2014 and 2015 were the golden years for the leather industry. We exported ₹180 crore worth of leather in FY15." Asad Iraqi of AKI India, who owns one tannery in Magarwara area of Unnao and one shoe manufacturing unit and saddlery manufacturing unit in Jajmau, witnessed exports of over ₹60 crore in FY22, significantly higher than the ₹52 crore of exports in FY21.

"There is no doubt that post Covid-19, there is an uptick in opportunities and that is being translated

into export values; the order book is very good as of now. This is because the western countries are drifting away from China, which is giving many opportunities to Indian businesses," says R.K. Jalan, Vice Chairman of Council for Leather Exports.

However, according to industry insiders, Kanpur's leather industry is grappling with multiple challenges, from paucity of skilled labour to lack of design capabilities, from unstable policies to logistical issues, and lack of availability of good quality and cheap accessories. "There can be no compromise on quality, which comes from skilled labour that is not available easily," says Asad Rizwan. Adds Iraqi, who exports fashion shoes and riding shoes